How to Tell Wild Animals

Introduction

This poem has been written by Carolyn Wells. In this poem, the poetess suggests some dangerously humorous ways to identify wild animals.

Summary

The poet says, if by chance you go to the jungles of the East and a huge terrible animal comes and roars loudly, and his roar is so frightening that you feel that you are dying, then you should understand that it is an Asian Lion.

She further says that if while roaming around, a wild animal with black stripes on yellow hide welcomes you and eats you, then this simple rule will teach you that it is a Bengal Tiger.

While further strolling, if you see an animal whose hide is covered with spots and it jumps at you and starts eating you, then you should understand that it is a Leopard. There will be no use shouting in pain because it will continuously leap on you and continuing eating you.

If you are just walking around in your yard and an animal meets you and it hugs you tightly, then believe that it is a bear.

You can also differentiate between crocodile and hyena. Hyena always smiles, but a crocodile always has tears in his eyes.

An original chameleon is like a lizard. It doesn't have ears or wings. If there is nothing on the tree, then you will see a chameleon there.

Message

This poem merely appreciates the diversity of animal kingdom and highlights the unique characteristics of different animals.

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Extract Based Questions ↘

Read the following extracts carefully and answer the questions that follow:

1. If ever you should go by chance
To jungles in the east;
And if there should to you advance
A large and tawny beast,
If he roars at you as you're dyin'
You'll know it is the Asian Lion....

(a) The Asian Lion is:

(i) huge and pale
(ii) large and tawny
(iii) big and bright
(iv) large and light

(b) Where can one find the Asian Lion?

(c) Fill the blank with one word.

The ..... will help us to identify the Asian Lion.

(d) According to the poet, how can you differentiate the lion from the tiger?

Answers

(a) (ii) large and tawny
(b) One can find the Asian Lion in the forests of the east.
(c) roar
(d) The poet suggests that we can differentiate the lion from the tiger on the basis of their appearance. The lion is large and brown-yellow in colour whereas the tiger has black stripes on the yellow skin background.

2. Or if some time when roaming round,
A noble wild beast greets you,
With black stripes on a yellow ground,
Just notice if he eats you.
This simple rule may help you learn
The Bengal Tiger to discern. *(CBSE 2023)*

(a) Who is the 'noble wild beast' in the above lines?
(i) Zebra (ii) Asian Tiger
(iii) Asian Lion (iv) Bengal Tiger

(b) Complete the sentence appropriately.
It is clear that 'Alliteration' is the poetic device used for 'roaming round' because ..... .
(Clue: explain how alliteration applies here)

(c) State whether the following statement is True or False:
The extract helps to identify a Royal Bengal Tiger.

(d) In the given lines, what effect does the poet create?
'Just notice if he eats you.
This simple rule may help you learn
The Bengal Tiger to discern.'
(i) Irony (ii) Terror
(iii) sympathy (iv) Criticism

(e) Which word in the extract tells you that you have recognised the 'noble beast'?
(i) Rule (ii) Discern
(iii) Roaming (iv) Notice

Answers

(a) (iv) Bengal Tiger
(b) alliteration is the use of the same letter or sound at the beginning of words that are close together as 'r' in 'roaming round'.
(c) True
(d) (ii) Terror
(e) (ii) Discern

3. If strolling forth, a beast you view,
Whose hide with spots is peppered,
As soon as he has lept on you,
You'll know it is the Leopard.
Twill do no good to roar with pain,
He'll only lep and lep again. *(CBSE 2023)*

(a) One can find out that it is a leopard by the way it .....
(i) leaps (ii) eats
(iii) looks (iv) roars

(b) State whether the following statement is True or False:
When an animal repeatedly leaps at a person, it is a leopard.

(c) Complete the sentence appropriately:
It is clear that repetition is the poetic device used for 'lep and lep again' because .....
(Clue: explain how repetition is applied here.)

(d) The Royal Bengal Tiger has black stripes on yellow skin whereas a leopard has .....

(e) Complete the analogy with a word from the extract:
claws : nails : : ..... : skin

Answers

(a) (i) leaps
(b) True
(c) repetition is a poetic device that involves using a word or a phrase for effect, two or more times in a speech or written work and the word 'lep' is repeated here.
(d) black spots all over its body.
(e) hide

Short Answer Type Questions

Q 1. How does the poet suggest that you identify the lion and the tiger?
Ans. According to the poet, we can identify a lion with its appearance. It is large and tawny in colour. A tiger is a noble wild creature. Its body is pale in colour and it has black stripes on its body.

Q 2. How does the Bengal Tiger look? Explain briefly.
Ans. The Bengal Tiger looks noble. He has black stripes on his yellow hide. He has terrifying teeth and is always ready to eat its prey.

Q 3. According to the poet, what does the bear do?
Ans. According to the poet, the bear embraces the man tightly. He also caresses him. The description of the bear has been presented in a very humorous style.

Q 4. What do we come to know about the chameleon in 'How to Tell Wild Animals'?
Ans. The chameleon is small like a lizard. It does not have ears. It also does not possess a single wing. It can also change its colour according to its environment.

Q 5. How does the poet create humour in 'How to Tell Wild Animals'?
Ans. The poet creates humour by describing different ways to identify wild animals. He says that one can identify a Bengal Tiger when he starts eating you and a leopard when he leaps at you. All this creates humorous pictures in the minds of the readers.

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Long Answer Type Questions ↘

Q 1. The quality of being amusing or comic is the best medicine for every ailment in life. Comment on the basis of your understanding of 'How to Tell Wild Animals'.

Ans. The quality of being amusing or comic is known as humour. It is infectious. When humour is shared, it binds people together and increases happiness. It strengthens our immune system, boosts our energy, diminishes pain and protects us from the damaging effects of stress. It is the priceless medicine for every ailment in life. The poet, in the poem 'How to Tell Wild Animals', creates humour by describing how to recognise animals. The way the poet explains the distinct characteristic of each animal is very funny yet interesting. The poet has depicted the wildlife very vividly and in a lively manner. While reading the poem, the reader's enjoy the poet's work and it leaves them refreshed and happy.

Q 2. Do you know what a 'bearhug' is? It is a friendly and strong hug—such as bears are thought to give, as they attack you! Again, hyenas are thought to laugh, and crocodiles to weep ('crocodile tears') as they swallow their victims. Are there similar expressions and popular ideas about wild animals in your own language(s)?

Ans. There are so many sayings about animals in mythology. In Hindu folk tales, it is said that a bear stands on his rear legs like a man and then he embraces the man or woman. It is believed that a hyena has a perfection in the art of mimicking man's laughter. 'Crocodile tears' is a much popular expression used all over India. Many tales are heard about snakes as 'Nag Kanya'. ●

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